

Bazaar

We test the latest and the best hardware and software products available in the market

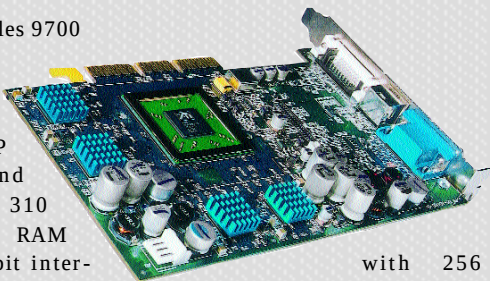
Hercules 3D Prophet 9700 Pro

When speed matters

The Hercules 9700 Pro graphics card boasts of an 8x AGP interface and 128 MB of 310 MHz DDR RAM with a 256-bit interface. With a maximum of 256 MB of RAM onboard, it can reach a bandwidth of 19.2 GBps! It has a 325 MHz core, eight rendering pipelines, dual 400 MHz RAMDAC for dual-monitor support and DirectX 9.0 support.

The 9700 Pro nicely blends form and function. It features an all-copper fan assembly and heat sinks on both sides of the card, which gives it a very powerful look. For the very first time, it actually packs a floppy-type power connector on the card, because the AGP bus cannot satisfy this power-hungry monster. So unless you have a power supply of at least 300 watts, don't even consider owning this graphics card.

We tested the card on a 2.2 GHz Pentium 4 processor, on the 845-based MSI Max2 BLR motherboard,



with 256 MB DDR RAM. In the 3DMark 2001 SE test, the card achieved an impressive score of 12,085. The *Unreal Tournament 2003* benchmark was also very high—130 fps when played at 1600x1200 in the flyby demo, with all settings at maximum level.

If you're looking for the fastest video card around, then this is the one for you. All this goodness comes at a high price, though—Rs 34,750 to be precise.

SPECIFICATIONS
ATI's R300 GPU, 128 MB DDR RAM, dual output, DVI to D-sub connector included, *The Elder Scrolls III: Morrowind* game CDs
System Requirements:
Pentium 4/III/II/Celeron or compatible with AGP 8x/4x/2x slot, 128 MB RAM, 300 watts power supply, Windows XP/Me/2000

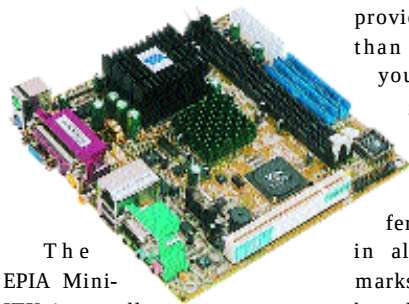
Hercules 3D Prophet		B+
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶	
Features	▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶	

Price: Rs 34,750
Contact: MediaTech India
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VIA EPIA Mini-ITX motherboard

Good things come in small packages

The VIA EPIA series motherboards are based on the EDEN platform and are intended as low-cost, ultra low-power and compact platforms for mobile and compact systems that are mainly used for surfing the Net, watching movies (DVDs), or working with office applications.



The EPIA Mini-ITX is an all-inclusive board that features an embedded VIA Cyrix C3 E-series processor with an optional fan-less EDEN ESP 5000 processor (these cannot be upgraded), support for up to 1 GB of 100/133 MHz SDRAM, AGP 2x Trident Blade graphics controller with up to 8 MB of memory with a TV Out option, AC '97 sound codec with S/PDIF output and a 10/100 Mbps integrated Ethernet.

There's only one PCI slot and one serial port, but this shouldn't be a problem, as its intended users will not need the extra expansion slots, and new devices can make use of the two USB ports (expand-

able to four) present.

When used with the fan-less EDEN ESP 5000 processor, the CPU heats up a bit during intensive operations, so a fan is recommended—when using the optional CPU with the fan, it was always at below-room temperature.

The motherboard system provides you with more power than you'll need for running your everyday business programs. Try to give it something even remotely graphical though, and it suffers—it performed poorly in all our graphics benchmarks. To be fair, this motherboard is aimed at the average budget user and not at gamers and graphics professionals and it's powerful enough to smoothly run DVDs and DivX movies. At Rs 4,500 for the 533 MHz variant, you really shouldn't be asking for more.

The motherboard supports processors ranging from 533 MHz to 933 MHz, and variants that support DDR memory are also available.

SPECIFICATIONS
Embedded 533 MHz processor, onboard AGP 2x graphics, integrated sound, 10/100 Ethernet, mini-ITX form factor, ATX-compliant power supply

VIA EPIA Mini-ITX		B+
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶	
Features	▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶	

Price: Rs 4,500
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